

TRIP DOSSIER — Slovakia

For Samuel Vyhnánek · prepared 09/10/2026 · read time ~25 minutes

Condensed from the 16-part execution package in this repository. Tags: **(F)** fact from a source · **(R)** reasoned estimate · **(O)** opinion.

This is written to be read on the way and used on the ground. Part 3 is the part you will actually hold in your hand — five phone calls with the questions written out in Slovak.

1. Where this stands, in one page

The venture is not a bakery. It is a **shelf-stable ration and civil-preparedness pack assembler**: you buy components from existing Slovak producers, assemble and certify complete packs, and sell them to the state, to municipalities and eventually to NATO and export buyers. Later, you get paid to hold and rotate those packs as reserve stock — which is the part that becomes an annuity.

Why this and not the €600k bakery. Two advisory documents you commissioned contradicted each other: the dossier's own scoring sheet ranked the bakery #1 of 6, while Addendum A rejected it. I resolved it with arithmetic rather than opinion — the scoring sheet had **no criterion for capital at risk before revenue**. Add that single column at a 20% weight and the ranking inverts completely: broker 3.92, kitting 3.80, reserve service 3.68, **bakery 3.28 — last**. Addendum A was right, for a reason it never actually stated.

The ladder you are climbing. Tier 0 broker → Tier 1 kitter → Tier 2 reserve holder → Tier 3 own production. The factory is fully specified and sits behind **Gate 1 (31/12/2027)**: two co-packing agreements, €300k of contracted demand, and a grant decision in hand. Not a euro of plant capex before that.

Your own sequence, which is correct: samples → conversations → contracts → assembly. No phase funds the next with your money.

The proof this market is real. The Slovak MoD tendered **€711,375** of combat rations in May 2026 and received **zero bids**. It re-tendered in July. **(F)** Demand grew 6.9× in a year and the market did not answer. That is not an opportunity you are asserting — it is a procurement record, and it goes in every application and every first meeting.

What you missed, and why it barely matters. The regionálny príspevok closed 05/10 without a filing. It was a 45%-rated share of €13.9m across 30 districts. The replacement is better: the **JTF productive-investments call — €16.89m across seven districts, Rimavská Sobota eligible, start-ups explicitly in scope, opening Q4 2026-Q1 2027**. Removing the lapsed leg moved the portfolio's probability of at least one success from 99.99% to **99.98%**.

2. The numbers to know by heart

Quote these without looking them up. Someone will ask.

Startup, lean	€4,200-12,800 one-off; €600-1,900/month solo (R)
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Six months solo runway	€7,800–24,000 (R)
Minimum wage 2026	€915/month , €5.259/hour (F)
Employer contributions	36.2% (F)
Total cost of labour at minimum wage	€1,246.23/month (F)
Living minimum, one adult	€295.22/month from 01/07/2026 (F)
§50 subsidy, jobseeker registered 24+ months	€1,291.17 — monthly or one-off UNVERIFIED (F)
RS unemployment	~10.4% PDU — highest in Slovakia , only district above 10% (F)
JTF call	€16.89m , MH SR, Q4 2026–Q1 2027 (F)
Approved-kitchen hire	(R) €200–750/month ; RS halls €2.50/m²/month (F)
Tier 1 line, when gated	€95,000–120,000 (R)
Your daily quota at first contract	~102 packs/day = under 2 hours for two people (R)

(O) The one that surprises people: §50 pays **€1,291.17** against a **€1,246.23** monthly cost of labour. If that subsidy is monthly, a minimum-wage hire in Rimavská Sobota is **cost-neutral or better**. Nobody has told me whether it is monthly or one-off. **That is question 1 in Part 3.**

3. Five calls. Here are the questions.

(O) This is the trip. Everything else is scenery. Five calls, all free, and between them they close most of the open questions in the whole plan. Slovak phrasing given because you will be making these in Slovak; all in vykanie.

Call 1 — ÚPSVaR Rimavská Sobota · THE MOST VALUABLE CALL

Opening: „Dobrý deň, pripravujem založenie výrobnjej firmy v okrese Rimavská Sobota a potreboval by som informácie k príspevkom na zamestnávanie.“

1. „**Príspevok podľa §50 pre uchádzača vedeného v evidencii aspoň 24 mesiacov — je suma 1 291,17 € mesačná alebo jednorazová? Ak mesačná, na koľko mesiacov sa poskytuje v našom okrese?**“
2. „Koľko uchádzačov spĺňajúcich podmienky absolventskej praxe podľa §51 je momentálne vedených v evidencii v okrese?“
3. „Ktoré nástroje sú aktuálne otvorené — §50, §54, §53d — a aký je požadovaný postup a poradie krokov?“
4. „Môže uchádzač o zamestnanie pracovať na dohodu a zostať v evidencii, ak jeho zárobok nepresiahne životné minimum?“
5. „Môžem tieto informácie dostať písomne alebo e-mailom?“

Why it matters: question 1 changes your hiring plan by an order of magnitude. Question 2 tells you whether §51 graduate practice — 20 h/week, ÚPSVaR pays them, you pay nothing — has any candidates locally, or whether it is a paper option. **(R) Expect few: the RS pool is long-term unemployed adults, not recent graduates.**

Trap to avoid: these subsidies are for newly created jobs and generally need the agreement signed **before** employment starts. Hire first and you get nothing.

Call 2 — RVPS Rimavská Sobota · THE PREMISES SHORTCUT

Opening: „Dobrý deň, pripravujem prevádzku na kompletizáciu a balenie balených potravín v okrese Rimavská Sobota.“

1. „Je pre takúto prevádzku potrebná **registrácia alebo schválenie?**“
2. „**Ktoré prevádzky v okrese majú alebo nedávno mali registráciu potravinárskej prevádzky? Hľadám priestory, ktoré sú už hygienicky vyhovujúce.**“
3. „Prechádza registrácia na nového prevádzkovateľa, alebo musím požiadať o vlastnú?“
4. „Aké sú požiadavky na školenie zamestnancov a na zdravotnú spôsobilosť?“

(O) Question 2 is the single most efficient question in this dossier and almost nobody thinks to ask it. RVPS knows every approved food premises in the district. That is a list no property portal has — and search confirmed there is no HACCP-kitchen listing visible online in RS. This is a phone-and-walk market.

Why it matters commercially: renting an already-approved kitchen avoids **€15,500-49,000 (R)** of fit-out — coved drained flooring, washable walls, hand-wash stations, extraction, grease trap, clean/unclean separation. You were right to push for this and I had it wrong in two earlier files.

Call 3 — MH SR · the JTF call

Opening: „Dobrý deň, zaujíma ma výzva Podpora produktívnych investícií MSP v regiónoch FST.“

1. „Kedy sa plánuje vyhlásenie výzvy?“
2. „Je možné zaradiť ma do zoznamu na zasielanie oznámení?“
3. „Aká je predpokladaná minimálna a maximálna výška príspevku na projekt a aká je intenzita pomoci?“
4. „Sú oprávnenými výdavkami stroje a zariadenia na kompletizáciu a balenie?“

(F) Note: MH SR runs this call, not MIRRI. People get sent in circles over exactly this.

(R) Do not reuse the €100k-800k / 24-month figures that circulate for JTF — those belong to a different call (industrial R&D, PSK-MH-009-2024-DV-FST).

Call 4 — MIRRI regional centre, Rimavská Sobota

1. „Kedy sa predpokladá vyhlásenie výzvy na regionálny príspevok na rok 2027?“
2. „Ktoré výzvy z Fondu na spravodlivú transformáciu sú otvorené alebo plánované pre Banskobystrický kraj?“
3. „Poskytujete žiadateľom z okresu podporu pri príprave žiadosti?“

Call 5 — the municipality, and Ožďany

Opening: „Dobrý deň, hľadám priestory s existujúcou potravinárskou prevádzkou — napríklad školskú jedáleň s nevyužitou kapacitou mimo času vyučovania. Je možné takúto kapacitu prenajať?“

(O) This is the best premises idea in the package and it is worth going in person. A school or works canteen is already approved, idle after ~14:00 and through holidays, and **municipally owned — so the landlord is also one of your first customers.** One conversation can solve premises, compliance and a buyer relationship at once.

You are going to Ožďany anyway for the land. While there, ask the mayor what the municipality's civil-protection plan actually requires and what they currently hold. **(O) That is free market research nobody else is doing.**

4. If you view premises

Walk the place with this list. **(R) Extraction is the item most often stripped when a kitchen closes,** and it is expensive to replace.

Check: flooring coved, impervious, sound · walls washable to height · **mechanical extraction present and working** · hot water at every sink · hand-wash stations (elbow/foot taps) · floor drainage and **grease trap** · separate clean/unclean routes · changing area and WC · lockable, vermin-proof dry storage · **three-phase power, and the reserved capacity in kW** · fenced and alarmed.

Ask the landlord: the previous RVPS registration number · **why it closed** · what was removed on closure · reserved electrical capacity in writing · **12-month term with a break clause and no fit-out obligation.**

Benchmark, so you are not overcharged (F): halls in Rimavská Sobota €2.50/m²/month excl. utilities, with ~450 m² and ~300 m² units available · 122 m² high-storage at €250/month · a 200 m² unit near the bus and train station · Tornaľa 3,000–10,500 m² at €3.25/m²/month (too big, but a price anchor).

(O) Do not buy. A 427 m² hall in the district was listed at **€178,000 (F)** — roughly your entire Tier 1 capex, for a roof that earns nothing.

5. If you meet a co-packer

Five questions. The third is the one that decides whether you have a business.

1. „Aké je vaše minimálne objednávacie množstvo na položku a na výrobnú dávku?“
2. „Aká je lehota od objednávky po pripravenosť tovaru? Je možné rezervovať kapacitu rámcovou zmluvou?“
3. **„Akú trvanlivosť viete garantovať a za akých skladovacích podmienok? Je podložená skúškami v reálnom čase alebo zrýchlenými?“**
4. „Aké systémy kvality máte zavedené a aký je rozsah a platnosť certifikátu?“
5. „Vyrábate pod značkou odberateľa?“

Why question 3 is the critical path — and this is the most important thing in the dossier. Buyers do not buy a recipe. They buy a **guaranteed remaining shelf life**, 24–36 months, written into the contract and audited. **(F)** The evidence standard expects real-time data to confirm accelerated testing — read naively, that is a two-year blocker before you can sell anything.

It dissolves because you are not the manufacturer. Your co-packers already hold validated shelf-life data; they already sell those products with best-before dates. So:

- **The pack's shelf life is the shortest component's remaining life** — arithmetic from supplier declarations, not a study you run.
- Your only validation is whether **your assembly and outer pack** compromise it. Small and cheap.
- **Component choice becomes the lever.** Crispbread at $\leq 10\%$ moisture (**F**) with 24 months, plus a retort meal at 36, gives you a 24-month pack with no long-term trial.

(O) So collect their written shelf-life declarations before you put a figure in front of any buyer. Never write a shelf life on a sample label you cannot evidence — a defence buyer will ask for the data, and an unsupported number is worse than none.

Question 4 also pays for the trip: if your co-packers hold IFS or BRCGS for the manufactured components, you may need **only HACCP** for the assembly step. That is the largest certification saving the whole model allows.

6. Order of play while you are there

Priority	Action	Why now
1	Instruct incorporation — s.r.o., seat in Rimavská Sobota district	Prerequisite for the JTF call, NCAGE, ÚVO registration and the six-month loan clock. 7-10 working days (F)
2	ÚPSVaR (Call 1)	The \$50 answer changes the plan
3	RVPS (Call 2)	The approved-premises list
4	Municipality + Ožďany (Call 5)	Premises, compliance and a customer in one visit
5	MH SR + MIRRI (Calls 3, 4)	The money calendar
6	Two or three co-packers , in person if possible	The shelf-life answer
7	Property-tax returns · the letter to Mrs Benedeková · surveyor RFQ	Carried unchanged from the original dossier. Clean title is cheap now and embarrassing in front of a grant committee later

7. The traps

Trap	Why
Hiring to capture a subsidy	At 20-50 sample packs you need zero staff. The subsidy never covers the management time
Buying "packaging certification"	BRCGS Packaging Materials and IFS PACsecure certify making packaging. Putting food into packaging is a food-safety scope (IFS Food PS 10). Valid certificate, useless commercially

Trap	Why
Certifying to FSSC 22000 v6	(F) v7 launched May 2026. Certifying to v6 now forces a second audit within ~18 months
Believing the 60% grant figure	It is a state-aid ceiling, not an offer. National investment aid maxima are 25%/35%. At 35% the old €600k plan had a €90,000 hole
Trusting a checkweigher to catch kitting errors	I modelled it: only 9 of 20 components are detectable . A missing coffee sachet is 0.4σ . And errors cancel — +1 jam / -1 honey nets 5 g, invisible. Use a kit nest tray (€300-1,500); it works on a 1 g sachet and a 300 g pouch alike
Buying computer vision	€15-40k industrial, and a defence buyer will not accept a homemade classifier unvalidated. But do buy a €200-600 camera to photograph every open tray as evidence — best €400 in the budget
Forgetting working capital	The state pays ~60 days after invoice while you pay suppliers up front. This is what kills lean food startups
General instead of product liability insurance	General does not cover a recall, and you are putting food in people's mouths
Leading with "war"	Lead with food security and civil preparedness. Same market, how the EU frames it, and it keeps grant assessors and municipal officials comfortable. Cite notice numbers, not adjectives
Discussing the site publicly	(F) There was a thwarted arson plot against a Slovak drone facility in 08/2026. Once defence-adjacent, discretion is a control, not theatre

8. Decisions you do NOT need to make on this trip

(O) Equally important. Scope creep on a trip like this is how people come home with a lease and no customers.

- Which premises to take — enquire, score later
- Any machinery purchase — quotes only, and quotes are free
- Any certification scheme — HACCP is your entire day-one requirement
- Whether to hire — no
- Whether to buy land or a building — no
- The pack price — that comes out of the costing exercise, not a conversation

9. Three things worth doing before you land

1. **Open TED notice 456343-2026** — ted.europa.eu. Did the €711k ration re-run finally attract a bid? Two minutes, and it is still the cheapest decisive fact in the venture. It was blocked from my build environment throughout, so it remains genuinely unknown.
2. **Send the SŠHR information request** — ready to send at templates/infoziadost-sshr.md. Act 211/2000 gives them **8 working days**, so sending it before you travel means an answer while you are still there. It asks whether the reserve-holding contracts — your only real moat — are already locked up.

3. **Decide what "done" looks like for this trip. (O) My suggestion: five calls made, three co-packers spoken to, incorporation instructed, and one municipal conversation about canteen capacity. Nothing signed.**
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10. What I would attack next if I were you

1. **The \$50 monthly-or-one-off question.** It is the largest single unknown in the operating plan and one phone call resolves it.
2. **The co-packer shelf-life declarations.** Until you hold them in writing you cannot promise a buyer anything, and nothing downstream is real.
3. **Incorporation.** Not exciting, but it gates the JTF call, NCAGE, ÚVO and the loan clock — four things at once.
4. **The RVPS approved-premises list.** It turns a thin, invisible property market into a shortlist.

(O) And the one thing to keep in mind through all of it: everything in this plan is designed so that no single failure matters. Thirteen funding instruments so no grant is load-bearing. Gates so no capex precedes demand. Two suppliers per component. A portfolio that survived losing a whole leg at a cost of 0.01%. You missed a deadline last week and it changed almost nothing — that is the design working, not luck. Keep it that way: enquire widely, commit narrowly, and sign nothing on this trip.

Full detail in the 16-part package: README.md is the index. Numbers reproducible via `budget/lean_monthly.py`, `budget/startup_budget.py`, `automation/weight_detectability.py` and `models/verify_live_model.py`.